PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

Best Guess Mock Exam 5: US Search & Destroy vs Vietcong Guerrilla Tactics (1965–68)

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (the difficulties faced by US soldiers during search-and-destroy missions in Vietnam):

• **Inference 1:** US soldiers struggled to engage an enemy they could not see in the dense jungle terrain.

- *Detail from source:* "You can't see the enemy, but you know they are watching... There are no North Vietnamese soldiers to shoot back at, just empty jungle and suspicious villagers..."

• **Inference 2:** Constant booby-trap casualties and unseen enemies produced severe psychological distress and destructive retaliation.

- *Detail from source:* "Suddenly, a tripwire is hit and a homemade booby trap goes off, killing two of our buddies... We are fighting a shadow, and it is driving us crazy."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

“One reason why US Search and Destroy tactics were unsuccessful in the years 1965–68 was that Vietcong guerrilla tactics neutralized the American advantage in firepower.” The Vietcong avoided large-scale conventional battles, choosing to fight in close proximity and utilize complex underground **tunnels** to evade detection. They deployed lethal **booby traps**, such as Punji pits and tripwires, which caused high casualties and constant paranoia among US troops. *Therefore, the Vietcong's guerrilla tactics made Search and Destroy missions unsuccessful because US patrols were constantly ambushed by an invisible enemy, preventing them from utilizing their superior weapons.*

“A second reason why US Search and Destroy tactics were unsuccessful in the years 1965–68 was that they actively alienated the South Vietnamese peasant population.” Search and Destroy operations relied on burning suspected villages, destroying crops, and killing livestock in what were often called 'Zippo raids.' This destruction of rural livelihoods completely undermined the US policy of winning the **hearts and minds** of the civilian population. *Therefore, civilian alienation made Search and Destroy tactics unsuccessful because it drove local peasants to support the Vietcong, providing them with food, cover, and vital intelligence.*

“A third reason why US Search and Destroy tactics were unsuccessful in the years 1965–68 was the flawed focus on body counts rather than holding territory.” The US military strategy of **attrition** aimed to kill more enemy fighters than they could replace, using helicopters to temporarily sweep areas before returning to base. However, this meant that once US forces withdrew, the Vietcong simply returned and re-established control over the villages. *Therefore, the focus on body counts and lack of territorial control made Search and Destroy unsuccessful because it resulted in temporary tactical raids that failed to establish permanent security or political control.*

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for showing the critical perspective within the US government regarding the counterproductive nature of US military tactics in Vietnam. The report highlights that "search-and-destroy operations and chemical defoliants" have created "hundreds of thousands of refugees" and are driving peasants "directly into the arms of the enemy." This content's utility is supported by my knowledge that US search-and-destroy missions and chemical spraying under Operation Ranch Hand devastated the South Vietnamese countryside, displacing millions of peasants and destroying the 'hearts and minds' campaign, which confirms that the report accurately identifies how US tactics actively fueled the Vietcong insurgency. The provenance of a US Senate Subcommittee report in 1968 increases its usefulness because it is an official, self-critical government investigation. This provides a highly reliable, objective contemporary record of the strategic failures of US military operations from the perspective of US policymakers.

Source C is highly useful for understanding the perspective of communist fighters and the impact of US military actions on the Vietnamese peasantry. The veteran states that US troops "treated everyone as Vietcong", burned huts, and killed livestock, which made "even the quietest peasants want to fight them." This is supported by my knowledge that US soldiers, frustrated by invisible booby traps and snipers, often retaliated against rural villages, which alienated the local population and made it impossible to isolate the Vietcong from the civilian support base, verifying the veteran's account of peasant recruitment. The provenance of a post-war interview with a Vietcong veteran in 1985 is useful for showing how communist forces perceived and exploited the mistakes of US military tactics. However, it is limited by hindsight bias and represents a highly partisan viewpoint of a victorious combatant, which may exaggerate the extent of peasant support for the Vietcong and downplay their own acts of terror.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that US tactics like Search and Destroy failed because they were counterproductive and **"alienated the South Vietnamese peasantry"**. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that the **"US tactics were militarily necessary"** to counter Vietcong guerrilla warfare.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have given weight to different sources. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source A, which describes US troops burning down thatched huts out of frustration, leading to the view that US tactics **"alienated the South Vietnamese peasantry"**. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source B, which outlines how search-and-destroy operations disrupted supply bases, leading to the view that **"US tactics were militarily necessary"**.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a moderate extent with Interpretation 2 that US tactics were militarily necessary. The Vietcong successfully neutralized US air and technological superiority by fighting in close quarters and hiding in dense jungle canopy. They constructed over 250 miles of underground **tunnels** (e.g. Cu Chi) that protected them from heavy bombing, and deployed cheap but deadly booby traps that caused massive US casualties. As described in Source A, these tactics created constant paranoia, making soldiers feel they were **fighting a shadow**. This supports Interpretation 2's view that search-and-destroy operations were militarily necessary because they **"successfully killed large numbers of enemy fighters"** and disrupted their supply bases, preventing them from overrunning South Vietnam.

However, Interpretation 1 is also valid in arguing that flawed US tactics actively caused their own failure. The strategy of attrition relied on **Search and Destroy** missions which measured success in body counts rather than holding territory. These raids, along with the spraying of **Agent Orange** and Napalm, devastated the countryside and destroyed peasant crops. As Source A reports, US troops burned down villages out of frustration. This chemical warfare and destruction of villages alienated the South Vietnamese peasantry, driving them to support the Vietcong. This confirms Interpretation 1's view that US tactics were **"self-defeating"** because they **"alienated the civilian population"**, making political victory impossible.

Overall, while the brutality of US tactics (Interpretation 1) lost the political battle for hearts and minds, it was the military effectiveness of Vietcong guerrilla warfare that created the stalemate in the first place. The Vietcong's ability to survive US firepower using tunnels and the Ho Chi Minh Trail forced the US into the destructive search-and-destroy tactics that ultimately destroyed their own political credibility.